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State news feed - Republicans make runoffs in 2 special Assembly elections Items found belonged to missing family

April 13, 2018 | Orange County Register, The (Santa Ana, CA)
Section: California | 230 Words
Page: 19
OpenURL Link

A Democrat and a Republican have advanced to a June runoff in each of two special elections to fill open Los Angeles-area Assembly seats.

Final Los Angeles County vote tallies released Thursday show Democrat Jesse Gabriel facing Republican Justin Clark in the 45th District. Democrat Luz Rivas and Republican Ricardo Benitez will compete in the 39th District. Democrat Antonio Sanchez was in third place by just 60 votes, but conceded the race Wednesday.

The upcoming contests will determine who will replace Assemblymen Matt Dababneh and Raul Bocanegra, who resigned last year.

Democrat Sydney Kamlager had previously emerged as the clear winner in the 51st District. She secured more than half of votes in her race and avoided a runoff contest.

The Mendocino County Sheriff’s Office said recovered debris and personal items confirm that a vehicle seen plunging into a storm-swollen Northern California river last week belonged to a family that went missing.

A sheriff’s office statement Thursday said the vehicle and its occupants haven't been located in the Eel River but searchers have found numerous items from the vehicle's body and interior. They said the items are consistent with a family on vacation and unspecified items were identified by relatives of the Thottapilly family.

The family of four — two parents and two children — was traveling from Portland, Oregon, to their home in Santa Clarita last week when they stopped communicating with relatives.

— From wire reports

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- **Citation (apa Style)**
  State news feed Republicans make runoffs in 2 special Assembly elections Items found belonged to missing family. (2018, April 13). *Orange County Register, The (Santa Ana, CA)*, p. 19. Available from NewsBank: Access World News – Historical and Current: https://infoweb.newsbank.com/apps/news/document-view?p=WORLDNEWS&docref=news/16B41F867B8EA0B8.